

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Expression of Ideas	Rhetorical Synthesis	Medium

Question

While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Scientists have long sought to determine the origin of glass in Chile’s Atacama Desert.
- A 2017 study concluded that ancient grass fires had melted the area’s sandy soil into glass.
- In 2021, a different study revealed that the mineral signatures of glass samples were consistent with the mineral signatures of comet samples collected by NASA.
- That study concluded that the glass had formed as a result of a cometary explosion close to the desert’s surface.

The student wants to describe how scientific understanding about the glass’s origin has evolved. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

Answer

- A. Scientists have long sought to determine the origin of the glass, with one study concluding that it formed when ancient grass fires melted the area’s sandy soil.
- B. Studies in 2017 and 2021 offered different explanations for the origin of the glass.
- C. Mineral signatures of glass samples are consistent with those of comet samples collected by NASA, according to new research.
- D. A 2017 study concluded that ancient grass fires had caused the glass’s formation, but new research suggests that the glass formed as a result of a cometary explosion close to the desert’s surface.

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The sentence describes how scientific understanding of the glass’s origin has evolved, explaining that new research suggests the glass formed as a result of a cometary explosion instead of being caused by grass fires (as was previously believed).

Choice A is incorrect. The sentence explains the conclusion of the older study; it doesn’t describe how scientific understanding of the glass’s origin has evolved. Choice B is incorrect. While the sentence indicates that the two studies provided different explanations, it doesn’t describe how scientific understanding of the glass’s origin has evolved. Choice C is incorrect. The sentence references a recent finding but doesn’t effectively describe how scientific understanding of the glass’s origin has evolved.